Thanksgiving: Celebration or Controversy?

Target Audience: B1+ / B2
Time: 45-50 minutes
Approach: CLIL + Socio-cultural approach
Format: Reading + Critical Analysis + Mini-Project

Lesson Objectives:

- Educational: Understand the historical origins of Thanksgiving and the modern debate around it.
- Linguistic: Practice vocabulary related to history and emotions (e.g., *harvest, gratitude, trauma, perspective*).
- Socio-cultural: Develop critical thinking by analyzing one event from different cultural perspectives (Native Americans vs. Settlers) and comparing it with how your own country treats historical dates.

Stage	Stage aim	Timing	Procedure	Aids and materials
Warm-up	Activate background knowledge and spark curiosity.	5 min	Teacher writes 3 statements about Thanksgiving on the board. 1. Americans eat 46 million turkeys on this day. 2. The first Thanksgiving lasted 3 days. 3. Thanksgiving was created by the US government in 2001. *(The lie is 3 — it became a national holiday in 1863).* Students guess the lie.	Presentation slide, 3 statements.
Controlled Practice	Pre-teach vocabulary for reading.	7 min	Match words with definitions: *harvest, gratitude, settler, trauma, perspective.*	Presentation slide
Reading	Develop reading skills for specific information and understanding two sides of a story.	10 min	Students read a short text with two perspectives (The Traditional View vs. The Native American View). They complete a Venn diagram or a table	Text Thanksgiving 2018: What Is the History of Thanksgiving? |

			comparing the two views.	National Geographic , National Day of Mourning — Mashpee Wampanoag Tribe
Post-Reading	Develop critical thinking and empathy.	8 min	Discuss: *"Why do you think some Native Americans call Thanksgiving a 'Day of Mourning'? Is it right to celebrate a holiday that is painful for some people?"*	Board for discussion
Freer Practice	Apply knowledge in a creative way	15 min	Group work. Students are museum curators. They must create a concept for an exhibit about Thanksgiving that shows *both* sides of the story (the gratitude and the tragedy). They present their ideas to the class.	A4 paper for brainstorming, markers, google doc
Homework and feedback	Summarize and reflect.	5 min	*"How should we remember historical events that have a dark side?"* Homework: Write a short paragraph (50 words): *"Is there a holiday in your country that has a controversial history? How is it treated today?"*	Notebooks

Match the words (1-5) with their definitions (A-E).

Word	**Letter**	**Definition**
1. Harvest	[ ]	A. A person who moves to a new place to live (often used for early American colonists).

2. Gratitude	[ ]	B. The process of gathering crops (food) from the fields.
3. Settler	[ ]	C. The ability to understand how someone else feels or sees the world.
4. Trauma	[ ]	D. A feeling of being thankful and grateful.
5. Perspective	[ ]	E. A very difficult or painful experience that affects someone for a long time.

Vocabulary Match

1. B
2. D
3. A
4. E
5. C

Thanksgiving: Two Perspectives

(Adapted from National Geographic and Native American educational resources)

Perspective 1: The Traditional Story

In 1620, a group of English settlers (the Pilgrims) arrived in North America. They had a very hard first winter, and many died. However, the Native American Wampanoag people helped them. They taught the settlers how to grow corn and catch fish. In the autumn of 1621, the settlers had a good harvest. They celebrated with a big feast and invited the Native Americans to join them. Today, Americans celebrate Thanksgiving to show gratitude for what they have: family, food, and freedom.

Perspective 2: The Native American Story

For many Native Americans, Thanksgiving is not a happy day. When the settlers arrived, they brought diseases that killed millions of Native people. Later, the settlers took their land and broke their promises. The peace between the Pilgrims and the Wampanoag did not last. Because of this trauma, many Native Americans call

Thanksgiving a *"Day of Mourning"*. They believe the traditional story hides the painful truth of what happened to their ancestors.

Read the text and complete the table.

	The Traditional View	**The Native American View**
What are they thankful for / What do they focus on?	1. _____ _____	2. _____ ____
How do they see the settlers?	3. _____ _____	4. _____ ____

Museum Exhibit Project

Situation: You are museum curators in Washington D.C. The museum is creating a new exhibit about Thanksgiving. Your boss wants an exhibit that shows BOTH the traditional celebration and the Native American perspective.

Task: In groups, decide on 3 items or sections for your exhibit. Write them below and be ready to explain your choice.

Our Exhibit Concept:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Why we chose these (Explain):